

The Password

The Encounter

I arrived at the last chapter of [The Inheritors](#) while sitting in my new apartment in Saigon, not as a reader might arrive at an argument, but as someone who had walked into that apartment and found it already furnished just for him.

Tuami was carving. The haft was still taking shape in his hand, not yet fully tool, not yet fully anything — becoming, the way Being itself becomes when nothing has closed it into a fixed thing yet. A devil child sat not as a threat, but a threshold marking an order that had already replaced the one Lok knew. And Tuami, feeling the ivory in his hand found waiting inside it, something he could not yet say. An unspeakable remainder.

Three years had passed since I arrived at Saigon airport. At that time Saigon for me was supposed to be only a hub to explore the unfamiliar cultures. It would turn out to be much more than that. I was on a journey, feeling my way along a path whose destination I didn't know where to, or exactly why I was on it. A new unfamiliar Asian world would perhaps jolt from me that which I could not yet say.

I felt myself go through the Golding page rather than read it. I saw the haft. Something held my attention on what Tuami was carving into the ivory. But I did not yet know what I was seeing. What I know now is that the not-yet-knowing was not a gap. It was the shape of something that had been building for years without announcing itself as preparation. What I saw, before I had words for it, was the haft not just as a handle. It was the whole project of a new kind of mind — the apparatus that grips the world by encoding it, that turns the immediate into the instrumental, that gives the new consciousness its foothold on everything Lok's people simply inhabited.

Something in me recognized the carving before I had a concept for what I was recognizing.

This writing is not the language of scholarship, and I want to be honest about that before the trilogy it points to asks anything of you scholarly. What happened to me reading Golding's final chapter was not an observation made from a critical distance. It was closer to what Vallega-Neu, in her study of Heidegger's Contributions to Philosophy, calls being transposed — appropriated into a transition that is not one's own achievement, that arrives rather than being reached. I did not conclude that the haft was technology in Heidegger's sense. I "saw" it, the way you might see an aged face from the past return to you once again.

I do not think this happened to me by accident, and I do not think it could have happened to just anyone, including an AI agent who opened the book that week. Something in my own trajectory had, without my noticing, built an

interior shaped to receive exactly this — seeing something that was always there, that generations of Golding scholars apparently walked past.

The Ground That Was Building

For years before that apartment, before I had ever thought about Heidegger or Golding or a haft, I spent my working life building categories for things that resist categorization. The material was incident reports — narrative accounts, written by nurses and physicians and technicians describing the moments when patient safety failed or nearly failed. My work was to build the taxonomies and the computational classifiers that could take that language — a plain, often shaken, account of what went wrong in a hospital — and turn it into coded fields: categories that could be counted, aggregated, tracked, compared across a system so large that no single person could otherwise see its patterns.

Yet a near-miss categorized correctly still leaves behind the things that cannot be coded. The long time is spent sincerely building a permanent working knowledge of human harm. But in the end you feel the edge of the categories the way you feel the edge of a table in the dark.

Those years spent were careful work, and necessary work, and it teaches you something no formal methods course prepares you for: the taxonomy is never the event. You can code a near-miss correctly, route it into exactly the right field, and the code will still leave behind everything that made it what it was — the fear in a voice, the particular way surprise overtakes protocol when established procedure goes wrong. You spend long enough doing this work and you stop mistaking the category for the thing. You develop a permanent, working knowledge of where representation ends. You feel the edge of the categories — not as an idea about limits, but as a physical habit of attention.

I had built a practiced interior that had already learned, at the level of daily practice, to distrust the sufficiency of its own best categories — to keep looking, past the coded field, for the remainder the field could not hold.

The Transition

Then I retired, and spent five years in Asia, outside the economy that had asked me, for decades, to keep building credentials, keep producing the next categorized output, keep proving myself legible to a system that only recognized what could be filed. I left for Asia perhaps looking for a more philosophical and spiritual position.

But the years in Asia were not a pilgrimage in the sense that pilgrims travel toward something they have not yet built the interior to receive. They were closer to the opposite: a dismantling of the structures that had organized my attention long enough for something else to become possible. I went because the credential-building loop had run

long enough that I could finally feel its edges, too — and stepping outside it, even briefly, is its own kind of practiced interior — that which I speak about in the trilogy.

But I want to be careful here, because it would be easy to overstate what leaving accomplished on its own. The trilogy that follows this paper makes a distinction — proximity is not access — and I have come to think my own five years are a case study in exactly that distinction. Distance from the credential economy was proximity: a change in geography, in schedule, in the pressures that had organized my attention for decades. It was not, by itself, ground. Plenty of people travel far from the systems that exhausted them and come back having changed nothing but the backdrop.

What made the difference, I think, was slower and less visible than the departure itself: the gradual withdrawal of a habit of mind that had spent many years asking, of every experience, how would this be categorized. Stepping outside that decision making loop repeated daily, a long unlearning of the reflex to translate experience into something that could be filed, reported, counted toward a next thing. You come back changed in a way that has nothing to do with what you accomplished while you were gone, and everything to do with what you stopped doing.

I did not know that while doing that work, taking that time, I was building the ground on which such sentences as Golding's would land with the full weight of recognition rather than the partial weight of interpretation. But I was. Proximity plus ground — the condition the trilogy will later name with more precision than I can offer here — is not a thesis I arrived at. It is what happened to me, and only afterward did I have the vocabulary to say what it had been.

I want to say plainly why this essay comes first rather than last. The three papers that follow argue, with the discipline that academic argument requires, that individual humans can be transposed into (or from) the exhaustion of a representational epoch and find something else made available on the other side of it — not through philosophical arrival but through structural convergence: linguistic evidence, narrative enactment, the testimony of the very old, the evidence of dreams. I believe that argument. But I did not come to it from outside. I came to it because it had already happened to me once, in the space of a single chapter, before I had a single citation to explain what I had felt.

The Thamus Argument

In Plato's [Phaedrus](#), King Thamus is offered writing by the god Thoth and refuses it, warning that it will produce not wisdom but the conceit of wisdom — people who appear to know because they can retrieve, without the understanding that once came from holding knowledge inside themselves. Thamus was wrong, or at least incomplete, and it is worth being precise about how.

Writing did not remove the cognitive loop it seemed to threaten. It externalized the products of that loop — the sentence, the record, the argument — while the loop itself, the living activity of categorizing, comparing, and

making sense, stayed inside a human being. Literacy became its own embodied skill, a new practiced interior that absorbed writing into daily competence rather than being displaced by it. Print did the same. So did calculation: the abacus, the slide rule, the spreadsheet each offloaded an output while leaving the operation that produced it — judgment, comparison, the sense of what a number meant — inside the person using the tool. Every prior information technology, in other words, has been a Thamus case: proximity to a new externalized product, absorbed because a human ground remained underneath it to do the absorbing.

I want to make a claim here that I could not have made with the same precision without the years spent building taxonomies, because that work is what taught me, in my hands rather than in the abstract, what a category actually captures and what it necessarily leaves behind. The category — the coded field, the taxonomy, the classifier — was always a product. It was the output of a loop that ran inside me: reading a nurse's account, sensing what mattered in it, weighing it against other cases I had seen, deciding where it belonged. No matter how good the taxonomy became, that loop stayed mine. The remainder — everything the code could not hold — stayed visible to me precisely because I was the one running the loop and could feel where it fell short.

What is different about artificial intelligence is not that it produces outputs the way writing or print or calculation did. It is that it runs the loop itself — the categorizing, comparing, and pattern-finding that used to require a human interior to perform — without a person on the inside of it feeling where the categories fail. It can classify an incident report the way I once classified them, at far greater speed and scale, and it will never feel the edge of the table in the dark — no surprise, no pressure carried forward, nothing deposited for a convulsion to work with — because there is no darkness on its side, and no hand reaching. This is why Thamus's precedent does not hold this time: the mechanism that proved him wrong about writing — a human loop, with a felt ground, absorbing a new externalized product into practiced competence — requires exactly the thing AI removes.

Another line of evidence against a Thamus analogy is [model collapse](#). Writing copied from copies remains stable; letters do not degrade because they are not generating new content from their own output. AI trained on AI output loses coherence because the loop has no embodied ground of its own. It requires what it cannot provide for itself: the lived experience of human beings as raw material. The engineering discipline required to prevent collapse — curation, provenance-tracking, deliberate re-grounding in human data — is the practical acknowledgement that the tool cannot sustain itself. Thamus was wrong about writing. The structure is different this time.

What the Trilogy Found

Read back through what has happened in this paper so far, and a structure appears that none of the three papers that follow could state this way, because none of them had a single life to state it about.

An encounter — reading a page and being claimed by it rather than interpreting it — that could not have happened without a particular ground already built: years of representational labor at the exact place where categories fail, followed by years of deliberate distance from the economy that rewards nothing but more categorization. Proximity to the book was not enough; ground was required, and the ground had been built without anyone, including me, intending it as preparation. This is the a3 condition the companion papers describe structurally — the interior that neither returns to naive immediacy nor stays trapped inside the categorizing loop, but has passed through the loop enough times to recognize, from inside, what it cannot hold.

What Tuami is carving into the ivory is a password the new consciousness cannot say — the unspeakable remainder, the thing the devil child marks without naming, felt rather than argued. I recognized it because I had spent a working life on the other side of exactly that boundary: building the fields that could say some things and feeling, every time, what they could not. The trilogy that follows formalizes this as a structural claim, tested across linguistics, narrative, the testimony of the very old, the evidence of dreams. I can offer my case as a case run to completion, in a single life, of the very thing the papers argue happens at the scale of an epoch: a loop exhausted from the inside, and something else becoming available on the other side of that exhaustion. Yet the examples live in us all.

A [co-authored paper](#) exploring the professional identity development process of mid-career EFL teachers provides an ordinary instance of finding the password. Bao, a participant in that study and a mid-career EFL teacher, describes reflection arriving unscheduled, apart from any deliberate technique: "Sometimes while I'm riding my motorbike, a sudden thought related to a lesson comes to my mind and I keep thinking about it." The ride supplies the proximity — an unstructured interval outside the classroom's representational demands. Nearly a decade of absorbed teaching practice supplies the ground. Neither alone would produce anything; the interval is available to anyone in traffic, and the practice, without the interval, remains merely operative rather than accessible. Their coincidence is what precipitates a thought Bao then finds himself unable to stop turning over.

And this carries practical significance. If the proximity arises from an unstructured interval meeting absorbed practice, then professional development programs may need reduced representational pressure, sustained embodied engagement, permission to let the credential phase be complete — under which the structural event of coincidence, unreachable by technique alone, becomes possible.

The first companion paper makes the philosophical and epochal case: tracing the arc from pre-Socratic immediacy through Cartesian modernity to artificial intelligence, arguing that AI represents not merely the intensification but the completion of the Western representational project — the first technology to externalize the loop itself rather than its products. The second grounds that claim in Halliday's Systemic Functional Grammar and Golding's narrative enactment of Neanderthal consciousness, showing that the stratum of meaning the loop covers over — the content plane, where experience is organized as figures before any clause captures it — is a real and distinct stratum, not a philosophical hypothesis. The third develops the empirical case through gerontolinguistic research on aging and

developmental research on dreaming, showing that two universal forcing conditions return human beings to that stratum, and that what determines whether proximity becomes genuine access is always the same variable: what a life has practiced. One case. Three angles. The same structure the apartment in Saigon handed me before I had the framework to receive it.

Closing

The companion papers will be read, if they are read, by people who come to them with their own trajectories already built — their own years of work at the edge of what their best categories can hold, their own distances traveled from the economies that organized their attention. I cannot know what ground they bring. I can only say that the argument is addressed to whatever in them has already felt the edge of the table in the dark, and knows that something was there that the category could not hold. The papers make that feeling precise. This piece is offered as evidence that the feeling precedes the precision — and that the precision, when it arrives, is recognition rather than discovery.

I think often of that apartment in Saigon. Largely because it is where I happened to be when something that had been waiting a long time finally had somewhere to arrive. The ivory was already there before I opened the book. Tuami had already been carving it for decades, in the incident reports, in the credential economy I stepped out of, in every category I built and then watched fail to hold what it was built to hold. I did not find the password that afternoon. I finally had the ground to recognize one that had been waiting for me all along.

Further Reading

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